▼ GLASSHOUSE



ROUGH ROAD FOR ROACHES

Saurav Das was the visible face of the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) during the Jantar Mantar protests. Yet, when the CJP held its first meeting in Assam in the last week of September, Das was conspicuously absent. The reason, though, was less political and more seasonal. Delhi's dengue outbreak had claimed another victim. The timing was unfortunate. Meanwhile, comrade Ashutosh Ranka was discovering that Assam is not Delhi. At the party's first volunteers' meet in Guwahati, Assam Police detained Ranka and several CJP members for hours before releasing them. The fledgling outfit's idea of democratic protests may find a tougher adversary here. Its mix of street theatre and combat on social media is unlikely to unsettle chief minister Himanta Biswa Sarma, who himself earned his stripes in street battles.

Illustrations by **SIDDHANT JUMDE**

▼ EARTHSHATTERING RETREAT

GOODBYE BULLDOZERS?

For years, the bulldozer was the BJP's favoured political symbol in Uttar Pradesh, synonymous with CM **Yogi Adityanath**'s 'tough law' politics. But it's wearing thin and, with election on the anvil, Samajwadi Party (SP) chief **Akhilesh Yadav** is cashing in on some of the negative vibes. When he launched his PDA Yatra from Raebareli on September 24, bulldozers lined the route showering petals with their buckets.



Akhilesh supplied the new slogan, "This time, the bulldozer of votes will roll." The irony is the BJP itself now seems wary of the big machines. Party president **Nitin Nabin** was en route to Meerut on September 21, when he saw a 'bulldozer welcome' at the Siwaya toll plaza. His cavalcade sped past without stopping. In Meerut, BJP members again brought out the bulldozers for him. Nabin was not pleased, for just days before there had been protests over demolitions in the Central Market. The message got through. Not one of the behemoths was seen at subsequent welcomes right up to Saharanpur.